The Adventures of Oliver Onions

A Novel of Silvora Reefs

Based on Malice in Underland

> *NATURE OF FAULT: structural, longstanding, load-bearing. REMEDY: none available. Recommend company.* — Maintenance form, Hang-Hi Quiet Apartments, Unit 2F

Part One — The Harbour

1 · The Bruise

The sky over Silvora Reefs bruised the way it always did, slowly, from violet toward a crimson it never quite committed to, and Oliver Onions lay on his back in eighteen inches of harbour water and watched it with the mild interest of a man who has not yet been told that he is the one who ought to be worried.

Something had come down out of that sky. He was fairly sure of it. The evidence was that he was wet, that the harbour smelled of hot metal apologising for itself, and that somewhere above the fog there were rotor blades: slow ones, heavy and unhurried, the sound of a machine that had arrived and meant to hold its position.

He did not know his name.

He did not know the town's, either, though the word *Silvora* sat at the front of his head like a parcel with no paperwork. He knew he was well past fifty, and that one knee had opinions. He knew the cold had stopped being an event and become a condition. And he knew, with a certainty that went down underneath everything else he had lost, that a little way off to his left, in the shallows, an elephant was waiting for him to finish a sentence.

The elephant was purple. He was the exact purple of a bruise on its third day, and he wore a saddle that had never once been sat in, and he stood the way very old things stand, as though the standing were a favour he was doing the ground. His name was Furthermore. Nobody had told Oliver this. He knew it the way he knew his own hands.

"Well?" said Oliver. His voice came out rusted. "Go on, then."

Furthermore drew himself up. The fog leaned in. Something enormous was being assembled behind those soft grey eyes, something that had been in preparation since before there were words to prepare it in—

“Nevermind,” said the elephant, and let all the air out at once.

Oliver laughed. It was a short, astonished bark, the first sound in the whole business that had belonged to him, because he had been maddened by that word for as long as he’d had a mind to be maddened with, and he would have known it in the dark. He did not know who he was. He knew precisely who this was. It seemed, on balance, a place to begin.

2 · The Correction

He waded out and turned and looked at what he had come down in.

It lay half in the shallows and half up the shingle where it had stopped. It was large, and it was broken, and it was broken in a way that objects of that size are not supposed to break: not crumpled, not burnt, but *struck*, as though something had hit it again and again in the same place until the place gave way. The metal was hot where the water wasn’t touching it. It ticked as it let the heat go, unevenly, like a clock being wound by someone who kept stopping to think.

There was no cockpit. There were no controls, no seat, no restraints, no housing for an instrument, nowhere a hand could have gone. There was no room inside it in which a man could have been sitting.

He had been inside it. He was as sure of that as he was of the elephant.

On one intact panel, stencilled small and neat and a little off-square, was a serial number, and beneath the serial number were four words in a language that turned into English while he was reading it and refused to stay that way afterwards. He knew that he had understood them. He could not have said what they were.

His pockets had been gone through by the tide and were still heavy with gold, which seemed to him a poor way to treat a man who had lost his hat. The hat was the one thing the water had taken. At the top of the shingle was a flat stone, and on the flat stone, laid out in a row as neatly as cutlery, were four things it had left alone.

A monocle, gold, on a gold chain, in a case worn shiny at the hinge by a great many openings.

A pocket watch, gold, stopped at 3:33, with its second hand held mid-sweep instead of resting against the pin. A spring runs down and the hand comes to rest. This one had been *held*.

A cane with a gold onion for a handle: a joke somebody had made once, long ago, and then had to go on living inside. The wear on the shaft said they had lived inside it cheerfully.

And a notebook, waterlogged, ninety pages of it gone to a single blue smear.

Three pages were still legible, dry in the middle of the ruin. The handwriting matched the callus on his second finger, same pressure, same slight backward lean, and he had no memory of writing a word of it. Under the thumbnail of that same hand was a stain he took for ink, violet going to crimson, and it did not come off when he rubbed it on his coat.

He put the monocle to his eye.

Through the gold, the wreck was not a wreck. It was a *correction*. Something had struck out, heavily, repeatedly, with enough force to tear the surface it was striking, and the tearing was what had come down over the harbour, and the sound of it was rotors because that was the nearest sound a man had for it. There had never been a machine. He had come through a hole made by somebody pressing too hard on a thing they were trying to remove.

He lowered the monocle. The wreck went back to being a wreck, which was not an improvement.

The notebook was worse. Through the gold the blue was not a smear at all. It was ink being *withdrawn*, page by page, back toward a nib, in a slow and careful retraction that had been going on for some time and was nearly finished. The three dry pages were not survivors. They were what had not been taken back yet.

The first held a map of a town he didn't remember, drawn in his own hand: a harbour, a street of lamps, a building marked with an X, and under it, in the backward-leaning script, *THEN WHAT?* The second was a letter that began *Dear Furthermore,* and stopped. The third was a list.

Eleven names. Nine of them had been ruled through, not scribbled out but *ruled*, once, neatly, the way a man crosses out something he is sorry about. *Olivier d'Oignon. Ollie Onyon. Oswin Unyan.* The nine went on in that vein, an alphabet of near-misses. The last two lines were blank. The ink there had gone first, and the lines hung on the paper, empty, like places laid at a table.

He read it twice. Then, because nothing in his life had prepared him to do otherwise, he put the notebook, the watch, the monocle and the cane into his coat, and went to look for the road.

The tide had left prints in the sand, and they were his; he knew the length of that stride. They ran from the water's edge to the foot of the slipway, straight and even, without the shortening and hesitation of a man on a wet slope in the dark. Walking like a man crossing a room whose shape he knew.

He lifted the monocle again. It showed him the same prints, and then showed him the part the eye had skipped: they did not come out of the sea. They *began*. Four feet out, under three feet of water, they began, already walking. And alongside them, coming down from the wall to meet them, was a second set, in a worn-heeled boot, which turned at the water's edge and hurried back up the hill beside his own.

Someone had been waiting for him. Someone had been in a hurry about it.

3 · The Slipway

The prints led him up the slipway to the harbour wall, and at the top of the slipway there was a truck.

It was a pickup the colour of weak tea, idling with its lamps dipped, and a man was leaning on the bonnet with his hat pushed back, wiping his hands on a towel in the manner of someone who has been wiping them for hours and has forgotten what they were wiped for. He was broad and slow and perhaps sixty. The shirt said DAREK. He had the look of a man who had been standing there since before there was anything to wait for.

"Sorry about your wait," the man said.

Then he stopped, and frowned at the harbour, and seemed to listen to his own sentence arriving.

"Ah. You ain't waited yet. Gimme a second. I'm runnin' a touch ahead this mornin'."

Oliver stood on the slipway with harbour running out of his boots and found, to his surprise, that he was prepared to trust this man entirely. It was not a decision. It was more like finding a stair where one expected a stair.

"You know me," he said.

"I know the Ols that comes in the shop. Tuesdays. Large vanilla, dipped, no sprinkles, and he reads the menu like he ain't read it for eleven years." Darek took in the wet coat, the cane, the monocle swinging on its chain. "Don't know who you are, though. You're standin'

different.”

“I don’t know who I am either.”

“Well,” said Darek. “That’s a start. Get in the truck.”

Afterwards Oliver would remember nothing of the drive. There would be a place in his memory where it ought to have been, smooth as a closed wound, and when he pressed on it he would feel only that something had happened there and had been handled with great tenderness. What he would remember was the truck stopping at the foot of a steep street, and the heater ticking, and Darek looking at the windscreen rather than at him.

“This is as far as I’m let go,” said Darek.

“Let by whom?”

Darek looked at the windscreen for some time. “Well, now,” he said. “Mind how you go, Ols.” And the second *Ols* was said the way you say a name to a man on a platform, either for the first time or the last.

Oliver got out. The truck did not leave until he had gone a good way up the street, and when he looked back its lamps were still there, dipped and patient, the way you watch a child cross a road.

Green lampposts went up the hill in a line. Each threw considerably more shadow than its flame could account for, and the shadows could not agree with one another about where the light was coming from. At his left shoulder something large and soft and purple kept pace, and the street, which had views on everything else, did not mention it.

He walked up between the lamps, into the parish.

Part Two — The Parish

4 · Hang-Hi Quiet Apartments

The sign said HANG-HI QUIET APARTMENT, with a gap at the end of it sized for a letter that was not there. Years ago someone with a spray can, a steady hand and a considerable sense of humour had supplied the missing S, and it was a snake: a snake coiled into the shape of the letter, painted so well that it seemed to be in the middle of deciding something.

Oliver had looked at that snake every day for eleven years. He knew it the instant he looked, the way he knew the knee. It had been in a different coil every single time, and he had never once caught it moving.

He lifted the monocle. The snake was not paint and was not a snake. It was a letter that had been typed wrong, struck through, and typed again, and the strike-through was what he had been reading as a body all these years. It was still wet. It had been wet since before he moved in.

He lowered the monocle and went in, because he was cold, and because there are things a man can only afford to learn one at a time.

The building had nine floors, and the second of them hung from something overhead rather than standing on anything below. The corridor ran from the stair to his door in a length that had never twice been the same. Tonight it was thirty-odd feet, and he walked every one of them with the feeling of being accompanied in the wrong direction. On the board outside his door were Landy's repair notices.

WINDOW 2F — WEATHER NONCONFORMING — RESOLVED.

DOOR 2C — OPENS TO 3A ON THURSDAYS — RESOLVED.

Each form carried the same four-lobed seal, stamped in violet: FILED WITH THE COALITION FOR CULPABILITY AND CONSTRUCTIVE CHANGE. NO FURTHER ACTION IS REQUIRED OF THE RESIDENT. NO FURTHER ACTION IS AVAILABLE TO THE RESIDENT. It took him a moment to see that the lobes were letters: four capital Cs, back to back, in a ring.

There were twenty-two forms. Through the gold, the word RESOLVED stopped being a word. It was the same three letters typed over and over on top of themselves, until the ribbon gave out and the paper gave up and agreed to be black in that shape. Nothing had been resolved. Something had been *insisted on*, at length, by someone who could not fix the corridor and could not stop filling in the box.

Inside, the flat had arranged itself into the shape it used when he had been away: chair angled toward the window, desk under its usual weight of paper, the smell of wet wool coming off a coat he had not yet taken off. The lamp was on. He did not recall leaving it on, but the lamp and he had an arrangement, and it had never yet been put in writing.

The desk was a door on two trestles. The left trestle was split along the grain and had never been mended; it had been shimmed, with something folded. He got down on his bad knee and drew the shim out.

It was a page: one of Landy's forms, filled in beautifully, in a hand considerably better than Landy's. Under NATURE OF FAULT it said *structural, longstanding, load-bearing.* Under REMEDY it said *none available. Recommend company.*

He did not raise the monocle. He knew what it would tell him: that the desk was not holding the shim up, that the shim was being held *in*, that somebody had kept one piece of paper somewhere safe and dry for eleven years and used a broken trestle as the excuse. He put it back exactly as it had lain, the way you would cover someone sleeping.

The window over the harbour stood a hand's breadth open and let in the rotors. Four days they had been going, he understood, at a constant bearing and a constant volume, and nobody had mentioned them; he knew that the way he knew the snake. He opened the window the rest of the way. With nothing between him and the sound, it stopped being rotors. It was a page being turned. Over and over, at the pace of someone checking what he already knew he had read, from a room that was not in the direction the sound was coming from.

By the window was a clean rectangle on the floor, with four small round depressions at its corners, pressed into the grain over so long a period that the wood had stopped intending to come back up. Something heavy had stood here for years. It had not been dragged away; a dragged thing leaves a lip of dust at the trailing edge, and there was none on any of four sides. It had been lifted straight up, by two men's worth of effort and no men, and the dust inside the rectangle was younger than the dust outside it. It had been taken and returned many times. The last time was inside the fortnight, and it had not come back.

Through the gold the rectangle was not empty. There was a machine standing in it, and the machine was being used, and the man using it had his back to Oliver and did not turn round.

The building was full of noises: a radio on four, a bath running on six, someone moving furniture on two. In eleven years he had never met or named one of those tenants. He tried now to put a face to the radio and found there was nothing to put it on. The radio was playing to an empty room. The bath was running into a bath nobody was going to get into. It did this on a schedule, and the schedule had been written by somebody who had once lived in a full building and remembered what one sounded like.

In the hallway hung a tall spotted glass. He had passed it ten thousand times. Now he stood in front of it and held still, and on a long enough hold the corridor behind his reflection stopped being the corridor. It became a room with a low ceiling and one lamp

with a green shade, and a desk under the lamp, and a great deal of paper on the desk, and a chair pushed back from it. When he raised the monocle, the gold declined to reflect the corridor at all and gave him the room directly: a desk, a lamp, a typewriter with a page in it.

There was a paragraph on the page. He could read it from where he stood; the page leaned toward him, the way a person leans who wants to be read. It was a paragraph about a man standing in a hallway looking into a mirror.

He stood very still, it said, *and read it.*

Oliver stepped back from the glass.

The last line, he was almost certain, added itself: *and stepped back from the glass.*

5 · The Management

He went down the stair because he could think of nothing else to do.

Asimov Sobeleaux kept the manager's office on the ground floor, behind a door that said KNOCK and, beneath it, in smaller letters, *or don't, I shall hear either.* He was a large, kind, weathered man who had once been a fisherman and once a cartographer and had not entirely finished with either. The walls were pinned with charts of waterways that appeared on no map, and he was bent over one of them with a pair of dividers when Oliver came in.

"Ah. The tenant who survives things. Come in, come in. Mind the corridor, it is longer today than it was contracted to be."

Oliver asked him why.

Asimov explained. It was a beautiful explanation. It had a beginning, a middle and an end; it dealt with load, and distance, and the way a building must be said to *stretch* to accommodate its occupants; it was delivered with dividers; and it made perfect sense for exactly as long as Asimov was talking. Oliver nodded all the way through it. He could feel it going even as he nodded, like a coin in a pocket with a hole. By the time he reached the door he had only the last line, which Asimov had pressed on him like a gift.

"One man needs more corridor than four men do," said Asimov. "One man has further to go."

On the stair, Luigi Luigi was mopping in the manner of a man conducting. He was short and wide and moustached, and he went through the building every day with a bucket and a squeegee and a total conviction that what he was cleaning was *dirt*. This was a gift, of a

sort. Rooms Luigi had just done behaved themselves. Stairs agreed to be stairs. The residents called him the Patron Saint of the Squeegee, and he permitted it as a thing that happened to other people.

“Ey! Mister Onions!” He did not interrupt the arc of the mop. “You walk on the wet floor, you take the consequences up with a higher authority. Me, I only do the floor.”

“Do you ever—” Oliver began, and could not think how to finish. *Notice that the stair is nine steps going down and eleven coming up? That the window on the landing has a different harbour in it every Tuesday?*

“The floor,” said Luigi kindly, “is the floor.” And he squeegeed the sentence away.

Lying Landy was under the sink on the first-floor landing, which was where he lived, in the sense that nobody had ever found him anywhere else. He was the building’s handyman, and he was immaculately dressed, with a pressed waistcoat and a bow tie and a pocket square, for a man whose elbows were in a drain. He emerged at Oliver’s step like a conjuror out of a hat, spanner in one hand and a smile that had been put on before it was needed.

“Mr Onions! Two-F! Now, the window. I’ve been at the window. It’s sorted. It’s completely sorted and I’d not want you to worry about the weather in it.”

“I haven’t asked about the window.”

“No. No, you haven’t. And that’s very, that’s very *good* of you.” The smile held, though something behind it was working hard at the holding. “Every repair I make, Mr Onions, I make *properly*. That’s the trouble. Do you know, I’ve been mending that corridor eleven years and it’s never once been the same corridor twice? I fix the one thing and the thing next to it takes offence.” He laughed, a very small laugh. “Resolved, though. All resolved. I’ve the forms.”

“I’ve seen the forms.”

“Then you know,” said Landy, with real relief, “that nothing more can be done,” and slid back under the sink.

Oliver stood on the landing for a while with the feeling of having been told the truth by three people in a row and having been given none of it.